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Talk about a kick in the teeth.

[Newcastle United](#) were absolutely fantastic against Barcelona. They battered them and looked to have earned a well-deserved win courtesy of a late Harvey Barnes strike, only for Malick Thiaw to press the panic button.

You can't blame Thiaw for sticking a leg out in the frantic final moments of Newcastle 1 Barcelona 1, but you have to think Lamine Yamal's last-kick-of-the-ball equaliser from the penalty spot makes this tie immensely more difficult for Eddie Howe and his players.

With a one-goal lead at the Nou Camp, it would have been finely balanced and Newcastle would have had a clear game plan going into their Champions League last-16 second leg.

Now Howe must mastermind something quite spectacular when Newcastle go to Catalonia next week, with the score tied at one goal apiece.

They still have a chance, they just had a much more realistic one of knocking Barcelona out had Barnes' goal been the winner it deserved to be.

Howe has displayed the ability to go to a European juggernaut and avoid defeat this season. [Newcastle were brilliant against reigning champions Paris Saint-Germain in the league phase](#), and Howe should copy that blueprint next week. A repeat performance would only be good for extra time, but it would have seen the Magpies through to the quarter-final of the Champions League had Thiaw not tripped Dani Olmo.

Tuesday's draw will feel like a defeat. On Wednesday, Newcastle fans should reflect and say to themselves, 'We were brilliant and can absolutely get a result next week.' Or something like that. Maybe a bit more Geordie.

Why not? Barcelona were outplayed in every department. Joelinton was a monster in midfield. Anthony Elanga actually looked decent. William Osula was a nuisance. Anthony Gordon will be fully fit. And Lewis Hall was simply outstanding, keeping Yamal quiet throughout.

So many Newcastle players played out of their skin and have to do the same in the second leg. While Yamal's equaliser could be a psychological blow that proves decisive in this tie, there should be belief in the Geordie camp that they can avoid defeat in Catalonia.

It's a big week for the Magpies, and facing Chelsea at Stamford Bridge on Saturday is far from ideal after such a gruelling evening against Barca.

Attention will undoubtedly be on that crucial second leg, with Newcastle absolutely in this tie, which is far from ideal when they need to get their Premier League campaign back on track. Lose next week and the pressure is on for Howe to achieve European qualification through their league position, with nothing else to play for after Manchester City knocked them out of both domestic cup competitions.

[Nine points separate Newcastle and the top five](#), which is pretty bleak. Chelsea being the side sat in fifth makes Saturday's game even more significant. It's a season-defining eight days, followed by hosting Sunderland in the league before the international break.

Tuesday's gut-wrenching draw to Barca will leave Newcastle feeling dejected for now, yet they have no choice but to dust themselves down and go again. If they keep playing like that, the Magpies could make something of this season, and are capable of getting something against Chelsea and then doing something very special at the Nou Camp.

Barca will be better at home and in front of their own fans, not the very loud St James' faithful, but this tie is not done, even if before the game we'd have said Newcastle had to win to stand a chance of advancing.

Newcastle should feel confident, but not as confident as Arsenal having watched Barca's display. Their p*ss-easy side of the draw looks even more pleasant for Mikel Arteta. [Atletico Madrid are the biggest threat if Tuesday's action is anything to go by](#).

Arsenal are in action on Wednesday night as Newcastle recover from a big boot to the teeth. Hopefully by then they'll be feeling significantly less dejected. It's up to Howe to make Tuesday's draw feel less like a loss and more like the terrific, dominant performance it was.

Newcastle still have a chance.

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